They were discriminated against in the army, often humiliated by Ashkenazi officers who viewed them as “primitive”. They were relocated to poor development towns on the northern and southern peripheries, with poor housing and lousy public services, located close to Israel’s dangerous borders. Their story was largely ignored in the official Israeli curriculum, a problem that persists to this day. In 1971, the widespread discrimination drove the descendants of Mizrahi immigrants to found a local wing of the Black Panthers.

Russians faced their own prejudice during the mass wave of *aliyah* in the late 1980s and early 1990s. The worst of it came from the rabbinate, which often doubted their Jewishness. They were not asked to dunk in ritual baths like the Ethiopians—but an estimated 200,000 of them are officially listed in the population registry as “other”, rather than “Jewish”, which makes it impossible to get married in Israel. An adviser to the Jewish Agency noted in 2012 that these Russian immigrants made up an overwhelming share of the Israelis leaving the country for good. “Because they are not considered Jewish here, it is much more difficult for them to feel a part of the country,” he said.[6]

The gaps have shrunk over the years, partly due to affirmative action programs (which are class- rather than race-based), partly due to marriage between Ashkenazi and Mizrahi Jews. But they remain stark. The curriculum is deeply skewed towards European history. A state commission that issued a 360-page report in 2016 offered some bleak conclusions. “The dominant stream in Israeli life still does not know the Mizrahi identity.” A high school student could graduate, it noted, without “being exposed to the Mizrahi voice at all, except for the poetry of the Golden Age in Spain.” Most of the prisoners in Israeli jails are Mizrahi. Among the judges who sentence them, 90 per cent are Ashkenazi.

But perhaps the starkest gap is economic: Seventy years after Israel was founded, the average city-dwelling Ashkenazi still earns 30 per cent more than his Mizrahi neighbor, a difference of more than $9,000 per year. Even for the comparatively well-off Ashkenazim in Tel Aviv, however, Israel is still a difficult place to earn a living.

A nation of immigrants